

UCLA - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-range Power 4 team with a credible rebound path, but the staff change and transfer-heavy depth chart make the No. 46 SP+ signal less stable than the No. 10 returning-production rank first suggests.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 46
Returning production	67% (No. 10) overall · Off. 73% (No. 5) · Def. 61% (No. 29)
Primer power rating	+5.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better overall: the quarterback returns, the backfield has a recognized centerpiece, and the new staff imported extensive system-familiar personnel, but the improvement case still depends on a rebuilt line and defense functioning together quickly.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Bob Chesney builds a ground-oriented offense around QB Nico Iamaleava/RB Wayne Knight, while DC Colin Hitchens tries to turn a transfer-heavy defense into a faster, more disruptive unit.

Bottom line: A 6-6 baseline is defensible, but the rebound depends on OL stability and a rebuilt defense fixing 2025's down-to-down failures.

Beats expectations if: QB Nico Iamaleava/RB Wayne Knight keep the offense on schedule, the OL settles early, and the new front creates more negative plays.

Disappoints if: OL/WR combinations remain unsettled and the transfer-heavy defense still allows efficient drives.

Five things to remember

- ◆ **New staff:** QB Nico Iamaleava is the high-confidence returning QB1 under a completely new staff.
- ★ **RB Wayne Knight:** RB Wayne Knight is the likely Week 1 lead with first-team AP recognition, backed by RB Jaivian Thomas/RB Anthony Woods.
- Returning production:** Returning production ranks No. 10, but many first-group WR/OL/front/secondary roles are transfers.
- ? **LB Trent Hendrick:** Eligibility and his active 2026 role remain unsettled.
- Schedule pressure:** The 2025 defense was No. 135 in success rate allowed/No. 130 in havoc; the schedule closes at Minnesota, Illinois, at Michigan and USC.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	3-9 (3-6 Big Ten)	● Very poor
Scoring	18.2 PPG	● Very poor
Total offense	319.9 YPG	● Poor
Rush offense	139.7 YPG · 4.5 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	5.98 YPA · 15 TD / 7 INT	● Below average
Third downs	37.3%	● Below average
Scoring defense	33.4 PPG allowed	● Very poor
Total defense	387.0 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	190.4 YPG · 5.2 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	196.6 YPG · 7.24 YPA · 23 TD allowed	● Poor

The traditional profile was bottom-tier: offense ranked No. 125 scoring/No. 120 total, while defense was No. 127 scoring/No. 119 against the run.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-3.11 · No. 94	● Below average
Off. EPA/play	-0.025 · No. 77	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	41.9% · No. 80	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	10.6% · No. 106	● Poor
Havoc allowed	15.6% · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	-2.48 · No. 89	● Below average
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.047 · No. 86	● Below average
Def. success rate allowed	49.7% · No. 135	● Very poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	13.0% · No. 97	● Below average
Havoc created	11.7% · No. 130	● Very poor

Advanced-stat read: Defense had the clearest structural problem: No. 135 success rate allowed and No. 130 havoc. Offense was less poor by EPA/success than scoring but only No. 106 in explosiveness, so both units need routine-down improvement.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Bob Chesney - from James Madison	● ↑ The same HC/OC/DC core arrives together, giving the reset more internal continuity than a pieced-together staff, but it is still a first-year UCLA installation.
OC / offensive play-caller	◆ Dean Kennedy - from James Madison; offensive play-caller	● ↑ Role clarity and a defined ground/motion structure are positives after a No. 125 scoring offense, though performance at UCLA is unproven.
DC / defensive system lead	◆ Colin Hitchens - from James Madison; defensive system lead	● ↑ The 2025 defense left substantial room for improvement, but the new scheme is being installed with a transfer-heavy front and secondary.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Wayne Knight	James Madison	● ↑ Likely lead back with first-team AP recognition.
◆ WR Landon Ellis	James Madison	● ↔ First-group receiver in a reworked room.
◆ WR Brian Rowe Jr	South Carolina	● ↔ Another first-group receiver replacing outgoing volume.
◆ OL Carter Sweazie	James Madison	● ↔ Projected first-group guard in a reconfigured line.
◆ OL Hall Schmidt	Boise State	● ↔ Expected right tackle; broader tackle/center uncertainty remains.

Out	To	Loss
WR Rico Flores Jr.	Virginia	● ↓ Material 2025 receiver departs.
WR Kwazi Gilmer	Nebraska	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 receiver departs from a rebuilt group.
TE Jack Pedersen	Washington State	● ↓ TE departure leaves the leading role to TE Phifer/TE Loftin.
OL Garrett DiGiorgio	NFL (Jacksonville), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Significant OL departure signed with Jacksonville; current pro status is reserve/injured.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Better at RB, but WR/TE/OL turnover offsets the gain during a new-system install.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Sammy Omosigho	Oklahoma	● ↑ Projected starting linebacker with Butkus recognition.
◆ DB Derrick Barksdale	James Madison	● ↔ Defined nickel role in the rebuilt secondary.
◆ DB Tao Johnson	Utah	● ↔ Expected free safety replacing 2025 departures.
◆ DL Aiden Gobaira	James Madison	● ↔ First-group edge/DE for a front that ranked No. 130 in havoc.
◆ DL Darold DeNgohe	Rutgers	● ↔ Likely interior starter in a rebuilt front.
◆ LB Trent Hendrick	James Madison	● ↔ Late addition under temporary court-protected fifth-year eligibility; roster status and football role remain unresolved.

Out	To	Loss
STAR Kanye Clark	Florida	● ↓ Starting-role departure removes hybrid-secondary continuity.
DT Siale Taupaki	Penn State	● ↓ Interior contributor departs from a rebuilt front.
DT Keanu Williams	Penn State	● ↓ Another interior contributor departs.
CB Andre Jordan Jr.	Auburn	● ↓ Secondary departure increases reliance on CB Pleasant/transfers.
DL Anthony Jones Jr.	Nebraska	● ↓ Material DL departure adds to front turnover.
DL Gary Smith III	NFL (Las Vegas), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful DL departure signed with Las Vegas and remained on the Raiders roster.

Defensive net: ● ↑ Better projected from a poor 2025 baseline, but rebuilt front/secondary roles and LB Trent Hendrick uncertainty widen the range.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Ground-oriented attack using shifts, motion and quarterback movement to create leverage; designed QB runs are a tool rather than the declared foundation.	QB lamaleava plus RB Knight/RB Thomas/RB Woods gives UCLA a clear QB-and-backfield spine.	The line remains configuration-sensitive and the top receiver group is transfer-heavy.
Defense	Hitschler emphasizes defenders solving offensive problems and playing fast within the system rather than depending on perfect calls.	LB Omosigho, CB Pleasant and a large transfer class raise the personnel ceiling across all three levels.	Continuity is low, and the 2025 defense was No. 135 in success-rate allowed and No. 130 in havoc creation.
Special teams	Returning kicker with an open punter competition.	K Bhaghani is an established current roster specialist.	P Barry/P Gerrand remains unresolved and SP+ places the unit only No. 71.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↔	Medium-high	QB Nico lamaleava is the established QB1 with Maxwell recognition, but he is learning a completely new offense.
RB	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	RB Wayne Knight is the likely opener with first-team AP recognition; RB Jaivian Thomas/RB Anthony Woods add depth.
WR	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	WR Matthews returns, but the leading group is transfer-heavy after material 2025 departures.
TE	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	TE Phiifer/TE Loftin are the main options after TE Jack Pedersen’s departure, with limited proven top-end production.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Low	The first group includes multiple new pieces, while center/tackle remain sensitive to health and competition.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	Transfer additions raise the talent level, but the front is largely new after a poor 2025 run/havoc profile.
LB	● B–	● ↑	Medium-low	LB Omosigho brings Butkus recognition and LB Jalen Woods returns; LB Trent Hendrick’s role/status remains unresolved.
Secondary	● B–	● ↔	Medium	CB Pleasant/DB Barksdale and transfer experience provide anchors, but the group still replaces several 2025 contributors.
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Medium	K Mateen Bhaghani is established; P Barry/P Gerrand remain in an open punter competition.
Coaching	● B–	● ↑	Medium-low	HC Bob Chesney/OC Dean Kennedy/DC Colin Hitschler arrive together from James Madison, preserving internal staff familiarity.
Overall	● B–	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ No. 46 fits an adequate Power 4 team whose QB/RB core is steadier than its OL and defense.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Nico lamaleava	QB	● Above-average Power 4 starter projection	Maxwell	The returning high-confidence QB1 is the single most important continuity piece in a new offensive system.
★ Wayne Knight (TR: James Madison)	RB	● Nationally recognized lead back	Associated Press 1st team · Doak Walker · Paul Hornung	The likely opener headlines the three-back structure and is UCLA's only first-team AP preseason honoree in the recognition layer.
Sammy Omosigho (TR: Oklahoma)	LB	● High-end conference starter projection	Butkus	Butkus recognition plus a projected starting role makes him the clearest defensive transfer centerpiece.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Rodrick Pleasant	CB	● Established returning starter projection	-	One of the most important returning pieces in a secondary otherwise mixing multiple transfers into major roles.
Derrick Barksdale (TR: James Madison)	DB	● Projected major nickel / system-fit starter	-	The defined nickel role gives Hitschler one transfer with clearer role certainty than much of the rebuilt defense.
Mikey Matthews	WR	● Projected first-group receiver	-	The returning receiver is one of the few continuity pieces in a top group otherwise filled heavily by transfers.
Eugene Brooks	OL	● Returning interior line anchor candidate	-	One of the limited returning OL continuity pieces in a unit whose center/tackle configuration is still fluid.
Trent Hendrick (TR: James Madison)	LB	● Late high-upside addition / unresolved active role	-	Current status verifies the late UCLA transfer/commitment, but temporary court-protected eligibility and official roster lag mean no settled role or unit credit should be assumed.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderately hard and back-loaded; UCLA has enough mid-tier opportunities to reach six wins, but the final month sharply raises the cost of early misses.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 36
Hardest stretch	at Minnesota → Illinois → at Michigan → USC
Swing games	at California, at Maryland, Wisconsin, Michigan State, at Minnesota
Advantage	After the Oregon trip, UCLA gets Wisconsin, Michigan State and Nevada consecutively at home before the difficult November finish.
Expected	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 3-9 record, No. 10 returning production and SP+ No. 46 create a rebound case, but Year 1 is fundamentally a translation test: staff/system familiarity helps only if a transfer-heavy roster can hold up at Big Ten line-of-scrimmage level.
Back them when	Mid-tier opponents cannot disrupt the OL and QB Nico Iamaleava/RB Wayne Knight keep the offense ahead of the chains.
Fade/pass when	Strong fronts or efficient rushing offenses can expose the reconfigured OL and transfer-heavy defense before either proves stable.
Key monitor	OL center/tackle configuration and OL Riley Robell/OL Jordan Davis availability, LB Trent Hendrick status/role, TE allocation, punter winner, defensive success rate/havoc
Week 1 baseline	UCLA -0.5 at California · essentially a pick'em on the primer ratings; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: UCLA -1.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

UCLA's rebuild has a useful head start because QB Nico Iamaleava is settled and RB Wayne Knight leads a credible three-back room, while the new Bob Chesney staff arrives with coordinator continuity from James Madison. That gives the offense a clearer floor than a typical first-year transition.

The uncertainty is practical lineup continuity: many first-group WR, OL, front and secondary roles are transfers, and the 2025 defense was among the nation's worst in success rate allowed/havoc created. The **SP+ No. 46** baseline and bowl-range

outlook are reasonable, but OL configuration and early defensive improvement must show up before the back-loaded final month.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coordinators](#) · [team strategy](#) · [RB preview](#) · [secondary preview](#) · [OL preview](#) · [LB Trent Hendrick](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026